

# Limits of self-reported applicant data

What the database mathematically contains is narrower than what it can support as a conclusion about graduate applicants.

| AMERICAN ACCEPTED | INTERNATIONAL ACCEPTED | GRE QUANTITATIVE MEAN |
|-------------------|------------------------|-----------------------|
| 38.53%            | 34.59%                 | 260.47                |

## Selection and representation

The 30,006 records in this database are a self-selected collection, not a random sample of graduate applicants. People decide for themselves whether to use GradCafe, which schools and programs to report, and whether an acceptance, rejection, waitlist, or unusually surprising result is worth posting. Applicants who never visit the site, prefer not to share an outcome, or come from communities where GradCafe is less commonly used are absent. Missing nationality and status values further change the denominator for a calculation. For example, the database shows a 38.53% acceptance percentage for 15,449 American Fall 2026 entries and 34.59% for 13,499 international entries. Those percentages accurately summarize the classified entries stored here, but they do not establish the acceptance rates of either applicant population. The difference could reflect which applicants post, the programs they apply to, or which outcomes they choose to disclose. The university submission rankings have the same limitation: high counts can indicate greater use of this website rather than greater application volume in the real world.

## Missingness and reliability

Anonymous self-reporting also limits reliability because no admissions office verifies the scores, labels, dates, or outcomes. In the current analysis, the stored values produce an average GRE Quantitative score of 260.47 and an average Analytical Writing score of 8.34. These results are warning signs that some entries may use incompatible score scales, place a combined score in a component field, or contain typing and parsing errors. Missingness compounds the problem: SQL averages each metric over only the rows that supply that metric, so GPA, Quantitative, Verbal, and Writing averages have different underlying groups even when they appear together in one result. Cleaning and LLM-generated program or university names can make text more consistent, but they cannot confirm that a score or admission decision is true. The reported averages are therefore mathematically correct for the non-NULL values in this database while remaining weak estimates of the broader applicant population. A careful analysis should report denominators, inspect score ranges, test how results change after questionable values are excluded, and describe these figures as patterns in GradCafe submissions rather than population statistics.